

Title: Keyword Audit Report

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Exports are downloadable from https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/15ZUOZSg48xgN1xi_kzKQAN1f-6n6MRnY?usp=sharing

Introduction

When media assets are tagged inconsistently, they become harder to find. This results in costing staff time, reducing SEO visibility, and weakening SMU's brand presence.

To address this, I analyzed the structured keyword list (used in Photo Mechanic and Adobe Bridge) against actual keywords in the Job Sheet and Catalog Layouts in FileMaker. The analysis showed which official keywords are used most frequently, and which additional terms appear outside the controlled list.

This baseline reveals how keywords are applied in practice and highlights gaps between internal tagging habits and SEO best practices. From here, we can make targeted improvements to boost discoverability in PhotoShelter, strengthen SMU's online presence, and establish a more consistent, QA-driven keyword process.

Tools:	Imports:	Exports:
- RStudio - Excel	Files Loaded: - SMUKeywords_08.05.25.txt - photoprocessandcatalogcompletelayout2025.08.23.csv - referred to as negsheet - jobsheetmain2025.08.23.csv - referred to as jobsheet	- Top 25 Keywords in jobsheet and negsheet (Figure 1 and Figure 2). - Frequency table: keyword_frequency_2025_08_23.csv. - Photos vs. Video Keywords keyword_by_source.csv. - Frequency of unstructured keywords: rogue_keywords_2025_08_23.csv. - Frequency of unused structured keywords: unused_taxonomy_2025_08_23.csv.

Key Findings:

- The top keywords (*Posed, Events, Groups, Portraits, Faculty*) dominate usage, which works for internal filtering but aren't what external users search for, limiting public discoverability.
- Keywords in Photo far outnumber Video usage (as expected). Photos lean visual/compositional descriptors (i.e. Portraits, Formal) while Videos lean contextual/action-based terms (i.e. B-roll, Interviews).
- Discrepancy in parent-child keywords. For example, *Signs* (2,310 hits) and *Signage* (2,155 hits) does not match in quantity. Enforcing parent-child rules improve both internal consistency and SEO strength.
- Street addresses of off campus locations appear in keywords, but external users tend to search by venue name and city.
- Job Sheet and Catalog records show tasks average 1-2 hours per job, though it's not always clear how much is media editing vs. metadata editing. Recent work logs show approximately 30+ hours per month on keyword reviews and corrections, suggesting that even small inefficiencies in metadata could add up to hundreds of staff hours per year.

Recommendations:

In line with SMU's Metadata Best Practices (and PhotoShelter), the following recommendations address both efficiency and discoverability.

1. Strengthen the keyword list against the exports. Expand with commonly used but missing terms, close the gap on inconsistent parent-child entries, audit unused taxonomy, and remove redundant variants to reduce noise.
2. For SEO, provide expanded, human-readable phrases and supplement with specific roles and locations. For example, *Posed* is useful to us in Filemaker as filter, which helps us separate from candid and event shots. However external users don't usually search "posed". They would search "President Turner official portrait at Dallas Hall" or "SMU president photo pony ears."

Example:	
Current use:	<i>President R. Gerald Turner, Portraits, Formal, Environmental, Posed, Pony Ears, Dallas Hall</i>
SEO-enriched additions:	<i>SMU President, Formal Portrait, Official Portrait, Environmental Portrait, Southern Methodist University, SMU, Former SMU President</i>

3. Workflow / technical terms like *B-roll* (501 hits), *Final* (369 hits), *Backdrop* (348 hits) might benefit greater in filenames or internal notes, instead of keywords. Most users would not search with those terms.
4. Prioritize street address or building / venue name in the sublocation IPTC field. In the keywords IPTC field use venue name first; if that is unavailable then use generic descriptors (i.e. Downtown Dallas, Off Campus).
5. Apply or develop a repeatable SEO workflow or automation tool(s) to ensure consistency, flag errors and typos, enforce parent-child links, and suggest SEO-rich alternatives.
6. Set quantifiable goals for SEO / user downloads, and track time spent on keyword drafting and reviews. Measuring effort will highlight inefficiencies and demonstrate time and cost savings once metadata processes are improved.

Conclusion

This audit shows that while SMU has strong tagging habits, inconsistencies and generic terms limit discoverability. Aligning with SMU's Metadata Best Practices and PhotoShelter/Google SEO guidance, I recommend refining the keyword list, enforcing parent-child rules, and using SEO-friendly phrases tied to SMU people, places, and events. A Keyword Optimizer tool or a repeatable SEO decision process will help enforce these checks, reduce staff time spent, and ensure consistent, searchable metadata across all assets.

Appendix

The Five Phases of Data Analysis

1. Get the Data

- **Source:** FileMaker (Photography Jobs) Job Sheet Main – 2015 and Photo process and catalog Complete layout
- **Files Loaded:**
 - SMUKeywords_08.05.25.txt
 - photoprocessandcatalogcompletelayout2025.08.23.csv (59 columns, 19,106 rows)
 - referred to as negsheet
 - exported all fields
 - jobsheetmain2025.08.23.csv (66 columns, 26,976 rows)
 - referred to as jobsheet
 - exported all fields

2. Clean the Data

- I conducted a quick, preliminary clean. It is not 100% clean; I applied quick techniques such as standardizing job numbers to character type, removing export artifacts and stray control codes, and applying a keyword cleaning function that stripped unwanted characters, collapsed extra spaces, trimmed whitespace, and converted all text to lowercase for consistency.

3. Prepare the Data

- **Filter:** Created subset tables selecting only the following columns:
 - Jobsheet_subset: Job_Number, Job_Name, Job, Job_Type, Fiscal_Year_Main_2015, Event_Date, Event_Location, Keyword_Review, Keywords_Copy, Photo_Need, Photos_Need_For, School_Name, Time_Estimate, Staff_Internal_External, Type_Of_Project
 - Negsheet_subset: Photographer_Initials, Job_Number, Negative_Number, Job_Name, Photo_Video_project, Event_Date, job_phase_production, Box_date_upload, Date_upload_to_Photoshelter, Keyword_Check, Keywords_catalog_process
- **Join/Merge:** Created a new table that unified keywords from both jobsheet and negsheet. Split on commas, semicolons, pipes, and "location:" and "optional:" markers. Exported as **keyword_unified_2025_08_23.csv**.

4. Analyze the Data

- Analyzed top keywords, frequency, comparisons against the structured keywords, keyword by source
- **Time Statistics:** Measured time data from Jobsheet and Negsheet:
 - Job Sheet (Keyword and Project Estimates)
 - 770 jobs with recorded time estimates
 - Median = 1 hr/job
 - Mean = 1.8 hrs/job
 - Neg Sheet (Production/Post-Production Time Logs)
 - Time Estimate = average .75 hrs/record
 - Time Freelance Post-Production = average .55 hrs/record
 - Time Post-Production = average .46 hrs/record
 - Time Post-Production Photographer = average .84 hrs/record

- **Exports:**

- Top 25 Keywords in jobsheet and negsheet exported as graphs.
- Frequency table exported as **keyword_frequency_2025_08_23.csv**.
- Keywords used by photos vs video exported as **keyword_by_source.csv**.
- Frequency table of terms outside the structured keywords exported as **rogue_keywords_2025_08_23.csv**.
- Frequency table of terms from structured keywords that are unused are exported as **unused_taxonomy_2025_08_23.csv**.

5. Present the Data

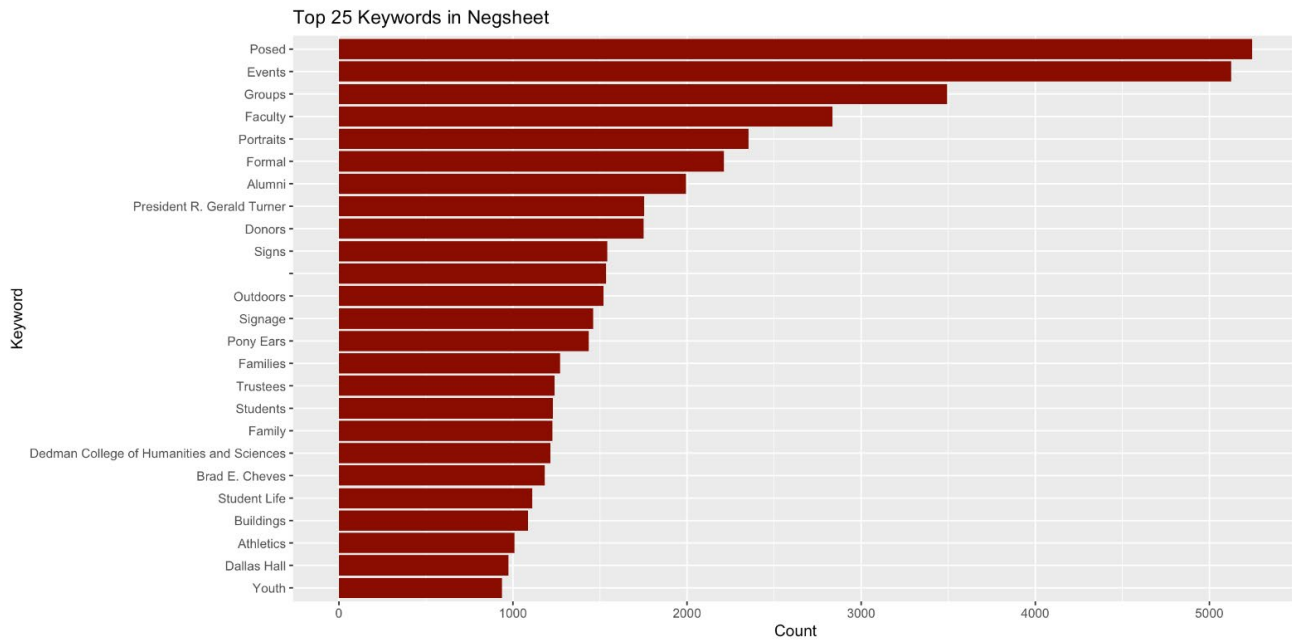


Figure 1 Top 25 Keywords in the Photo Video Process Catalog

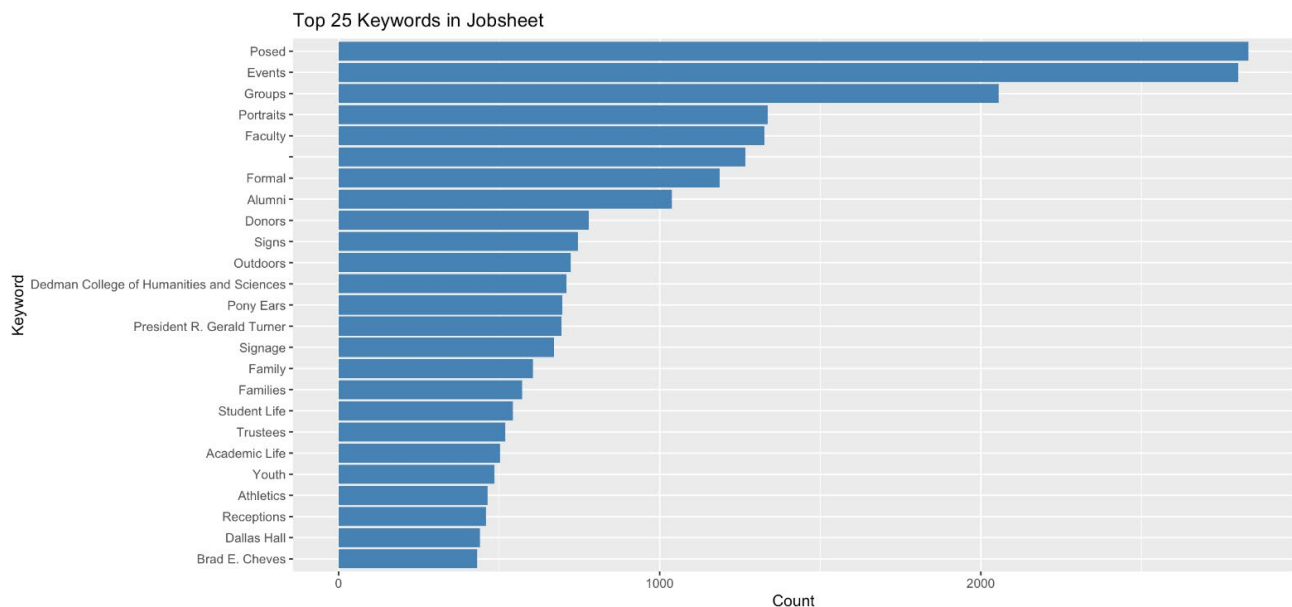


Figure 2 Top 25 Keywords in Job Sheet